POLITICAL REALISM

Realism has been the most dominant school of thought in the post-World War II international relations and still continues to have relevance in the present international relations scenario. The principal line of thinking of the realist school is in terms of power and its exercise by states. In other words, it is chiefly concerned with *realpolitik*.

The basic assumptions of realism are:

1. The international system is anarchic.
2. Sovereign states are the principal actors in the international system.
3. States are rational unitary actors each acting under the consideration of its own national interest.
4. National security and survival are the primary 'national interest' of each state.
5. In pursuit of national security, states strive to increase national power.
6. National power and capabilities determine the relations among states.
7. National interest, defined in terms of national power, guides the actions of the states in international relations.

The seeds of realism, however, could be traced to the writings of political philosophers like Thucydides, an ancient Greek historian who wrote the *History of the Peloponnesian War* and is also cited as an intellectual forerunner of realpolitik, Chanakya's *Arthashastra;* Machiavelli's, *Il Principe* (*The Prince)*; Thomas Hobbes' *Leviathan*; Otto von Bismarck, a Prussian statesman who coined the term *balance of power* and Carl von Clausewitz a nineteenth century General Prussian and military theorist who wrote *On War* (*Von Kriege*) in which he propounded his greatest dictum that *war is nothing but a continuation of politics by other means*.

Their understanding of *realpolitik* deeply influenced the political realists' perspective of looking at world politics especially from the viewpoint of human nature which they relocated in the sphere of